of his royal neighbour the Chalukya king Kirtivarman, is the most likely candidate for the cutting of two of the greatest monuments of Western India: the vast rock-cut temple-cum-cave of Kailasa at Ellora, which has its own rather crudely cut Nataraja bas-relief, and the no less magnificently executed rock-cut cave-temple of Shiva on Elephanta. The latter has the usual Shiva linga at its heart but the shrine's real masterpiece is the massive Nataraja in a side-chamber. Although badly frayed by a combination of monsoon rainwater and Portuguese musket practice, enough has survived of the original to convey the god's superhuman energy and movement (see illustration on page 247).

Beyond a couple of passing references I have also said nothing about another of the Kannada-speaking dynasties, the Rashtrakutas, who under Raja Govinda III forced all four southern dynasties – Cholas, Pandyas, Cheras and Pallavas – to bend the knee in tribute, and whose son Amoghavarsha boasted that his father's horse had drunk from the icy streams of the Himalayas and his war elephants from the sacred waters of the Ganges, and yet apparently cared enough for the well-being of his subjects at a time of famine to sacrifice a finger to the goddess Lakshmi in a bid to bring rain, and who at the end of his life abdicated to become a Jain monk.

But the Imperial Cholas do cry out for more space, not least because they were the only rulers of India whose ambitions extended across the black waters of the *kala pani*. In the Rijksmuseum van Oudheden in the university town of Leiden in Holland there is an unusual souvenir of the Dutch VOC's trading links with the Coromandel coast. It takes the form of twenty-four copper plates held together on a ring closed with the seal of the Chola kings: a seated tiger facing two fishes standing on their tails, flanked by two lamp-stands and topped by symbols of royalty in the form of a parasol and two fly-whisks. These so-called Leiden Plates had been found in the village of Anaimangalam, on the